



STORY STUDIO

Scientific Communication *Training*

An intensive programme to strengthen the presentation and communication skills of emerging surgical leaders, built around the COMMENCE trial data.

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PREPARED FOR

EDWARDS LIFESCIENCES



The Importance of *Connection*

Edwards Lifesciences is looking to strengthen the scientific communication skills of its emerging surgical leaders, helping them to present clinical research with clarity, confidence, and presence at international conferences and professional events.

At Whipsmart Media, **we understand this challenge**. We have been helping researchers and clinicians communicate their science for the past 13 years and enjoy an unrivalled depth of expertise and experience in this area. We **fully believe that the focus on scientific communication is the right path** to help surgeons share their work with their peers, stakeholders, partners, or the public in a way that truly resonates.

Story Studio is a training programme built for this very purpose. It is grounded in **evidence-based communication science**, 23 years of media experience and 13 years of professional training, and has been shaped over five years by feedback from **hundreds of participants**. It has been delivered to researchers, clinicians, and industry professionals at institutions including Royal College of Surgeons in Ireland (RCSI), University of Galway School of Medicine and Nursing, Pfizer, Johnson & Johnson, A. Menarini, and Abbott.

We have extensive experience in the **medical device and pharmaceutical sectors**, including Medical Science Liaison (MSL) training, pitch development, and spokesperson preparation. We have also been fortunate to **have worked with Edwards Lifesciences previously**, providing communications training at your Limerick facility and in Dublin on a number of occasions.

"In science, we remove ourselves to pursue the objective truth. But to communicate that science in a way that truly connects, we need to put ourselves back in. Passion, conviction, context, and humanity are at the heart of effective engagement."

JONATHAN MCCREA, WHIPSMART MEDIA

Technical *Proposal*

Overall Approach

We propose a tailored version of our established Story Studio programme, delivered as an intensive one-and-a-half-day workshop for cardiac surgeons at Edwards Lifesciences. Story Studio is **highly interactive and practical**, giving participants the tools and confidence to communicate clinical research in a structured and audience-centred way.

The programme combines clear, evidence-based communication principles with structured practice activities and constructive feedback in a supportive environment. By the end of the training, participants will have **presented multiple times**, received detailed individual and group feedback, and will leave with a **proven framework and digital tools** to continue developing their communication skills.

The training uses a number of different approaches, including Barbara Minto's **Pyramid Principle**: a structured methodology for organising ideas from the top down, so that the most important message leads, supported by evidence beneath. This is particularly effective for clinical and scientific presentations, where dense data can overwhelm even expert audiences. We also draw on the presentation design principles and data storytelling methodology of **Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic**, author of *Storytelling with Data*, to help participants present clinical data visually and clearly.

In our experience, when a scientific expert fails to connect with the audience, it is rarely the expertise of the speaker or a failure of the science that is the issue. **It is the communication. Surgeons who present their research with clarity and human connection are the ones who get invited back**, who build collaborations, and who move their field forward.

With the COMMENCE trial's seminal 10-year data now published, there is a real opportunity to help your emerging surgical leaders tell that story well: not just with data, but with **the patient impact behind it**.

Pre-Work (Distributed 2 weeks before)

- **Pre-course survey:** Self-assessment of communication confidence, experience, and goals. This gives us baseline metrics for measuring improvement.
- **Lay abstract:** Each participant writes a plain-language summary of their research or a dataset from the COMMENCE trial that they wish to present.
- **Slide preparation:** Participants prepare 3-5 slides on their chosen topic (their own research or COMMENCE data). These will be used in workshop exercises.



Day One *Sessions*

SESSION 1: LANGUAGE

The Building Blocks of Scientific Communication

Morning / 90 minutes

We begin with introductions and set the scene: this training is an opportunity to build a foundation for better communication generally. We then explore the three types of language that make communication memorable: **visual** (language that helps us see), **emotional** (language that helps us feel), and **logical** (language that helps us believe). This is **particularly powerful for clinicians**, who tend to default heavily to logical language at the expense of engagement.

- Demonstration of how the balance of these language types transforms a clinical message
- Quick exercises: Empty Photograph (visual storytelling from data), Emotion Mapping (identifying how clinical research connects to patient experience), and Three Pieces of Data (choosing just three data points to tell a compelling story)
- Paired exercise: participants rewrite a section of their lay abstract using the language techniques and deliver it
- Group discussion and feedback

Break: 15 minutes

SESSION 2: STORY

Structuring Your Science

Mid-Morning / 90 minutes

Introduction of simple, repeatable story frameworks for research communication:

- **Setup-Conflict-Resolution** (ideal for presenting new data that challenges existing practice)
- **Problem-Inspiration-Payoff** (ideal for innovation and new therapies)
- **Past-Event-Present** (ideal for presenting new directions, explaining how the clinical landscape has shifted and why a new approach is necessary)
- Exploration of creative techniques, including "prisming" (presenting the same COMMENCE data from different stakeholder perspectives: surgeon, referring cardiologist, hospital administrator, patient), employing suspense, and using the "Opposites" storytelling device
- Group activity: participants restructure a technical abstract into a clear narrative. In pairs, they deliver this three consecutive times, improving through constructive feedback



What Clients *Say...*

"Jonathan is a masterful and engaging presenter. He touched on the emotions of his audience members in a way that allowed us to be a part of the stories. He gave us tangible tools that we can immediately use in our work. This was a terrific session that we plan to model throughout our team."

Communications Director
Global Medical Devices

"The training was an extremely valuable use of my time. It increased my confidence, the structure of my talk and how I communicate my science."

Prof Lydia Lynch
Harvard University

"His sessions are lively, thought-provoking and practical. He also played an important role in the communications and pitch training for the ARC Hub for HealthTech, a centre focused on connected health and medical technology innovation."

Niamh O'Connor
Head of Strategic Communications | BioInnovate Ireland, University of Galway



Day One *Continued*

SESSION 3: PRESENTING WITH DATA

Slides, Structure, and the Pyramid Principle

Early Afternoon | 90 minutes

This session focuses on how to present clinical data in a way that is clear and appropriate for the audience. Many researchers **overload slides with data**, losing their audience before the key message lands.

- The Pyramid Principle in practice: structuring a presentation **from the conclusion down**, not the methodology up
- Slide design principles: **what to show, what to say, and how to manage the gap between the two**
- The "behaviour change" framework: before building any presentation, define **what you want your audience to think, feel, or do differently** afterwards
- Exercise: participants **restructure their pre-prepared slides** using the Pyramid Principle and present a **3-minute version** to a small group
- **Facilitated feedback** on clarity, structure, and audience connection

Break: 15 minutes

SESSION 4: ON CAMERA AND DELIVERY

Presence, Voice, and Performance

Late Afternoon | 75 minutes

This session covers the **physical and vocal dimensions** of presenting, including **on-camera performance**, a skill increasingly required as organisations record interviews, panel discussions, and promotional content with their clinical experts.

- Confidence, presence, and non-verbal communication: what the research tells us about **how audiences perceive speakers**
- Voice use: **pace, pause, emphasis, and the power of silence**
- On-camera exercise: each participant delivers a **60-second summary of their key message to camera**, followed by **playback and individual feedback**
- Discussion: **adapting your story to different formats** (conference podium, panel discussion, internal meeting, recorded interview)
- Reflection and preparation notes for Day 2



Day Two & Post-Training *Support*

SESSION 5: BRINGING IT ALL TOGETHER

Final Presentations and Feedback

Morning | 150 minutes (plus 30 mins break) | Close: 12:30pm

The final session is where everything comes together. Each participant delivers a **full 5-7 minute presentation** incorporating all the techniques covered: structured narrative, effective data presentation, engaging language, and confident delivery.

- Each participant presents to the full group
- Structured peer feedback: every participant provides written observations using a feedback framework
- Detailed individual feedback from the trainer on content, structure, delivery, and presence
- On-camera recording of final presentations for personal review
- Group reflection: key takeaways, personal action plans, and commitments

Story Studio Portal (12 months access)

- **AI-powered communication tools** trained on the Story Studio methodology, for analysing language, creating metaphors, structuring narratives, and building presentation plans
- **The Content Tool**, a structured planning template for any future presentation or communication engagement
- **Course materials and reference guides** from the workshop
- **30-day email support**: participants can reach out with specific queries related to an upcoming presentation or communication opportunity

Post-Course Reporting

A follow-up survey measures changes in communication confidence, likelihood of applying techniques, and qualitative feedback. Whipsmart Media will also provide a summary report identifying participants who demonstrated particular aptitude for communicating clinical evidence, along with recommendations for follow-up activities.

"We strongly recommend that Edwards plans a tangible follow-up activity for participants after the course: a recorded video, an internal panel, or an opportunity to present at an upcoming event."

RECOMMENDED POST-TRAINING OUTPUT

Edwards Lifesciences *Context*

This programme has been designed to support Edwards Lifesciences' commitment to advancing clinical education and evidence dissemination. With the publication of the COMMENCE trial's 10-year data, there is a clear need to ensure that the surgeons closest to this evidence can communicate its significance effectively to peers, institutions, and the broader clinical community.

COMMENCE Data Dissemination

Helping surgeons bring the COMMENCE trial's 10-year data to life through patient stories, clear structure, and audience-centred delivery, so that the clinical significance of the results is understood and felt.

Pan-European Group Dynamics

The programme works effectively with participants from different cultural and linguistic backgrounds, all presenting in English. We frame communication improvement as a universal life skill, not a competition, which creates a safe and productive learning environment.

Conference and Event Readiness

Preparing surgeons to present clinical evidence confidently at international congresses, panel discussions, and professional events.

Varied Skill Levels

The programme works with mixed groups, from strong presenters who need refinement to less experienced speakers who need foundational skills. The iterative, practice-based approach ensures **every participant improves from their own starting point**.

Delivery and Management

Trainer: Jonathan McCrea, Whipsmart Media, will design and deliver all sessions

Preparation: A pre-session briefing call of 1 hour will be held in advance to align on objectives, discuss compliance considerations, gather participant information, and finalise the agenda

Materials: Course handbook, Content Tool template, and access to the Story Studio AI portal

Group Size: 10-12 participants

Location: Edwards Lifesciences headquarters, Switzerland (or alternative venue as agreed)

Timing: To be confirmed, early summer 2026

About *Jonathan*



Jonathan McCrea has spent his career telling and listening to stories. He is a **multi-award-winning TV and radio broadcaster** and founder of Whipsmart Media, a communications consultancy based in Dublin.

He is the creator of Futureproof, Newstalk's flagship science programme, which has won **11 national and international radio awards** over its 15 years on air. He has presented 10 series of Ten Things To Know About, the critically acclaimed science television series for RTE, and produced and presented The Great Guide to the Future, a travel and science documentary distributed internationally through **Discovery Channel, Amazon Prime, and BBC World**.

For the past 13 years, Jonathan has trained researchers, clinicians, and industry professionals in the art of scientific communication through Whipsmart Media. He founded the science communications conference SCI:COM and sits on the board of **Science Media Centre Ireland**.

Clients include: Edwards Lifesciences, Pfizer, Abbott, Novartis, Johnson & Johnson, Docusign, Citibank, Danone, Diageo, RCSI, TCD, UCD, University of Galway, University of Limerick, University of Cork, Maynooth University, Teagasc, and BioInnovate Ireland.



Investment

Programme Design & Consultation	Pre-training consultation, briefing call, material customisation, pre-course survey design, compliance review coordination, and post-training reporting	€2,500
Training Delivery	1.5-day intensive workshop (3 half-day sessions x €4,500)	€13,500
Travel Days	2 half-days at 1/3 session rate (€1,500 x 2): travel to Switzerland the evening prior and return to Dublin following completion	€3,000
Story Studio Portal	12 participant licences (12 months) for the online AI-powered communication toolkit, course materials, and 30-day post-training email support (valued at €200 per participant)	<i>Included</i>
Total		€19,000

PAYMENT

25% on signing of contract, 75% upon completion of training.

VALIDITY

This proposal is valid for 60 days from the date of issue.

TRAVEL & EXPENSES

Flights, accommodation, and local transport are not included and will be billed separately at cost.

VAT

VAT is not applicable. Services supplied to a business established outside the EU.